How the GitHub CI of mediatools Works

Quality gates, workflow, runners, Python versions, containers and the gh command line tool

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2026-11-10 (release 1.2.14)

Abstract

This document explains what happens between `git push` and a green or red check on GitHub for the project mediatools. It corrects a simplification used earlier in the chat ("the local run is mirrored on the server"): nothing is mirrored; the same gate script is executed a second time, on machines owned by GitHub, from the commit that was pushed. The document walks through the workflow file line by line, describes the runner virtual machines (hardware, operating system labels, privileges, time and concurrency limits, cost), explains how the Python versions of the test matrix are provided and which other versions can be selected, shows the three ways Docker containers can be used, and explains how the `gh` command line tool talks to GitHub through the REST and GraphQL APIs, including authentication and the calls made by `apply-release.sh`. A chapter shows the branches (`main` = former `master`, `develop`, `feature`, `release`, `hotfix`) as parallel lanes and marks for every step which gate run belongs to it. State: release 1.5.1 (CI for pull requests on Python 3.10 and 3.14, the tag run only checks the tag, pip downloads cached, retries of GitHub calls in `mediatools update`). The document is part of the repository (`docs/ci-guide.md`) and changes with every release that changes the CI. Branch protection, costs and limits, self-hosted and Forgejo runners, a command cheat sheet, a glossary and the sources close the document. Facts were checked against the GitHub documentation and the local `gh` 2.89.0 help texts on 2026-11-10.

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1 How to read this document

This guide lives in the repository as `docs/ci-guide.md` with the PDF next to it; it is built and checked like the other documents (section "Building the documentation" in `docs/developer.md`), so it belongs to the release it describes.

All commands on the developer PC run as a **normal user**. `git` changes only the clone, `gh` acts on GitHub with the user's own token. Neither needs `sudo`. The only place where `sudo` appears is inside the workflow file: it runs on GitHub's virtual machine, not on the PC.

Two numbers recur everywhere and are worth fixing first:

Term	Value in mediatools
Repository	`github.com/peddanet/mediatools`, **public**
Workflow file	`.github/workflows/tests.yml`, workflow name `quality-gates`
Gate script	`tools/check.sh` (privacy, format, lint, types, security, tests)
Test matrix	CPython 3.10 and 3.14 on `ubuntu-24.04` (since 1.5.1; 3.10, 3.12, 3.13, 3.14 before)
Required checks	`gates (3.10)`, `gates (3.14)`

2 The big picture: executed twice, not mirrored

The phrase "the local run is mirrored on the server" is imprecise. The server never sees the local result. What happens is:

1. **Locally**, `tools/check.sh` runs before each push (pre-push hook, activated once with `git config core.hooksPath .githooks`). It runs in the PC's environment: one Python version, the locally installed tools. It is a **filter for the developer**, and it can be bypassed with `git push --no-verify`.
2. **On GitHub**, the push or the pull request is an **event**. GitHub reads the workflow file *from the pushed commit*, starts one fresh virtual machine per job, checks out exactly that commit, installs the tools and runs the **same** `tools/check.sh` again, once per Python version. The result is stored as a **check run** on the commit SHA. This run is **authoritative**: branch protection only accepts it.

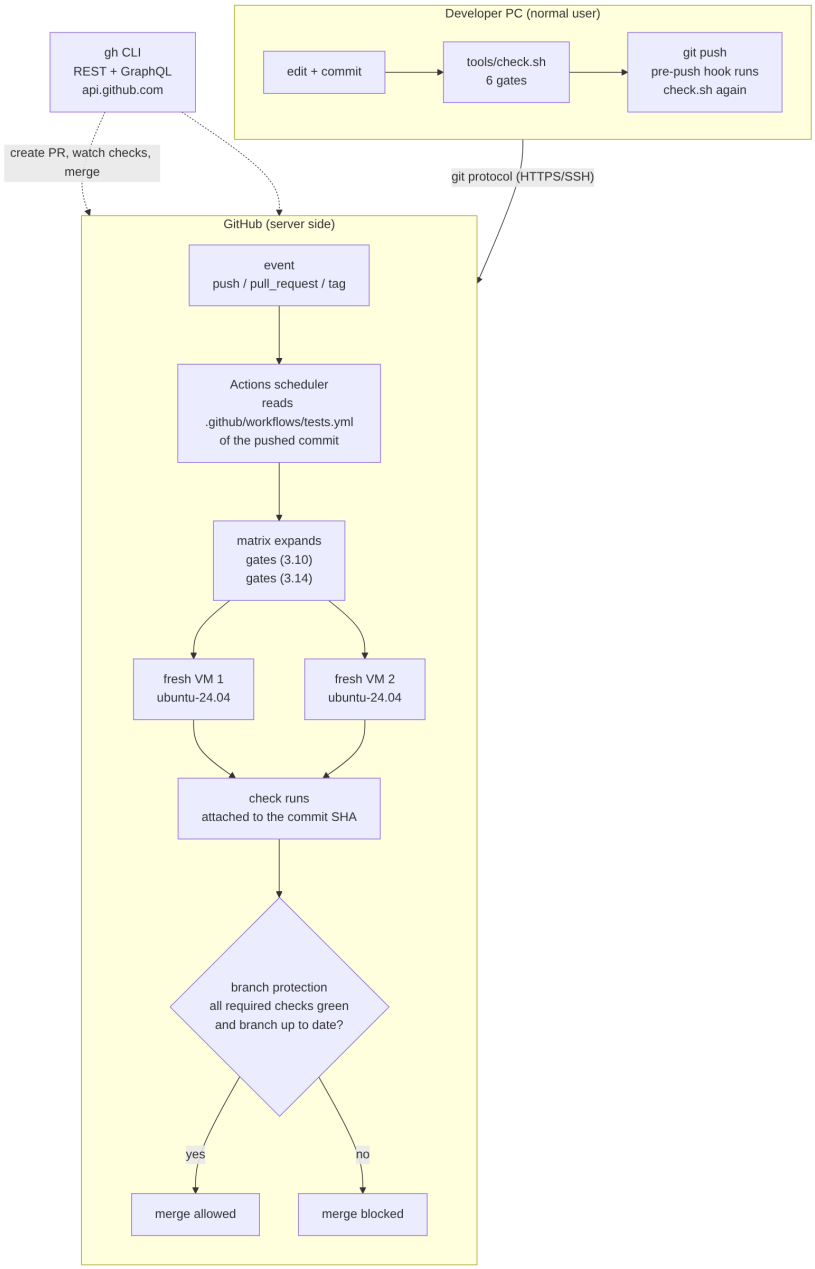


Figure 1: From the local gates to a merge on GitHub

The identity of the script is what makes the local run a good *prediction* of the server run. Differences remain and explain the rare “green locally, red on GitHub” case:

Aspect	Local (pre-push)	GitHub (CI)
Machine	own PC, state accumulates	fresh VM per job, deleted afterwards
Python	the one in the local venv	3.10 and 3.14, one VM each
Tools	as installed (`pip install -e ".[dev]"`)	installed anew on every run
Files	working tree incl. untracked files	only what is committed

Aspect	Local (pre-push)	GitHub (CI)
Privileges	normal user	user `runner` with passwordless `sudo`
Bypass	`--no-verify`	none (rule applies to admins too)

The “Files” row is the most frequent cause of a difference: a test that reads an untracked local file passes locally and fails on GitHub.

3 The workflow file, line by line

GitHub looks for YAML files in `.github/workflows/` of the commit that triggered the event. The mediatools workflow (excerpt, comments removed):

```yaml
name: quality-gates
on:
  push:
    tags: ["v*"]
  pull_request:
    branches: [main, develop]
  workflow_dispatch:
```

Key	Meaning
`name`	display name; also used by `gh workflow run quality-gates`
`on.push.tags`	run when a tag v* is pushed (release); only `release-check` runs then
`on.pull_request.branches`	run for a PR whose **target** is `main` or `develop`; the run tests the merge result of PR head and target
`workflow_dispatch`	allows a manual start: `gh workflow run quality-gates --ref BRANCH`

No branch has a push trigger (since 1.2.13). Work branches are tested through their pull request. A merge into `main` or `develop` produces the tree its pull request already tested (`strict` branch protection, no direct pushes), so a run after the merge would only repeat that test; until 1.2.12 these two extra runs per release existed and made the Actions list hard to read. Chapter 4 shows every run per branch.

```yaml
jobs:
  gates:
    if: github.ref_type != 'tag'
    runs-on: ubuntu-24.04
    strategy:
      fail-fast: false
      matrix:
        python: ["3.10", "3.14"]
    steps:
      - uses: actions/checkout@v5
      - uses: actions/setup-python@v6
        with:
          python-version: ${{ matrix.python }}
          cache: pip
          cache-dependency-path: pyproject.toml
      - name: system tools
        run: sudo apt-get update && sudo apt-get install -y ffmpeg rsync rsnapshot xvfb
      - name: python tools
        run: pip install -e ".[dev]"
      - name: quality gates (format, lint, types, security, tests)
        run: tools/check.sh
```

Key	Meaning
`jobs.gates`	job id; the check names become `gates (3.10)` and `gates (3.14)` (job id plus matrix value)
`if: github.ref_type != 'tag'`	the gates do not run for a tag push: the tagged merge commit has the tree its pull request already tested
`runs-on`	runner **label**: selects the machine type (chapter 5)
`strategy.matrix.python`	one job per list element, all started in parallel; the oldest supported and the newest version, the pre-push hook covers the PC's version in between
`fail-fast: false`	a failing version does not cancel the other one; default would be `true`
`uses:`	runs a published **action** (a versioned program from another repository); `checkout@v5` runs on Node.js 24
`cache: pip`	`setup-python` keeps pip's download cache between runs, keyed on the hash of `pyproject.toml`
`${{ matrix.python }}`	expression; replaced by `3.10` or `3.14` in the respective job
`run:`	shell command on the VM (bash on Linux runners); a non-zero exit code fails the step and the job

The second job only runs for release tags, and it is the only job of a tag run:

```yaml
  release-check:
    if: startsWith(github.ref, 'refs/tags/v')
    runs-on: ubuntu-24.04
    steps:
      - uses: actions/checkout@v5
        with:
          fetch-depth: 0
      - name: tag is on main
        run: git merge-base --is-ancestor "$GITHUB_SHA" origin/main
      - name: tag matches version
        run: |
          v=$(sed -n 's/^__version__ = "\(.*\)"/\1/p' src/mediatools/__init__.py)
          test "v$v" = "$GITHUB_REF_NAME" || { echo "tag $GITHUB_REF_NAME != v$v"; exit 1; }
```

Until 1.5.0 the tag run repeated all gate jobs first (`needs: gates`); since 1.5.1 it only checks the tag, which shortens every release by one full gate run. `fetch-depth: 0` fetches the full history (default is only the one commit), which `git merge-base` needs. `GITHUB_SHA` and `GITHUB_REF_NAME` are environment variables that GitHub sets in every job (commit and tag name). Tags are not covered by branch protection, therefore this job is the guard against a tag on the wrong commit or with the wrong version.

4 Branches and gate runs side by side

4.1 `main` is the former `master`

The original git-flow model (Driessen, 2010) calls the branch with the released versions `master`. GitHub creates new repositories with the default branch `main` since 1 October 2020; existing repositories keep their name. Name and role are the same: in mediatools `main` holds only released states, each tagged `vX.Y.Z`. There is no separate `master`.

Branch	Role	Created from	Goes into
`main` (= `master`)	released versions, each tagged	-	-
`develop`	integration of finished work	`main`	`main` via a release
`feature/x`	one piece of work	`develop`	`develop` (pull request)
`release/X`	version number, CHANGELOG, PDFs	`develop`	`main` (pull request)
`hotfix/X`	urgent fix of a release	`main`	`main` (pull request)
`merge/hotfix-X`	helper of `mediatools update` for the back-merge	`main`	`develop` (pull request)

4.2 Reading the lane diagrams

Every branch is a vertical lane; time runs downwards. A **solid arrow** is a git operation from one branch to another (create a branch, merge). A **dashed arrow** is a pull request: the proposal to merge, which GitHub tests before the merge button is unlocked. The badge on the right names the gate run of the step:

Badge	Where	What
LOCAL	this PC, pre-push hook	`tools/check.sh` with the Python of the venv, on the working tree; can be bypassed with `--no-verify`

Badge	Where	What
CI	GitHub, fresh VM per job	`tools/check.sh` with Python 3.10 and 3.14 on the committed tree (pull requests); for a tag only `release-check`; binding for branch protection
none	-	no test: the pull request tested the same tree before

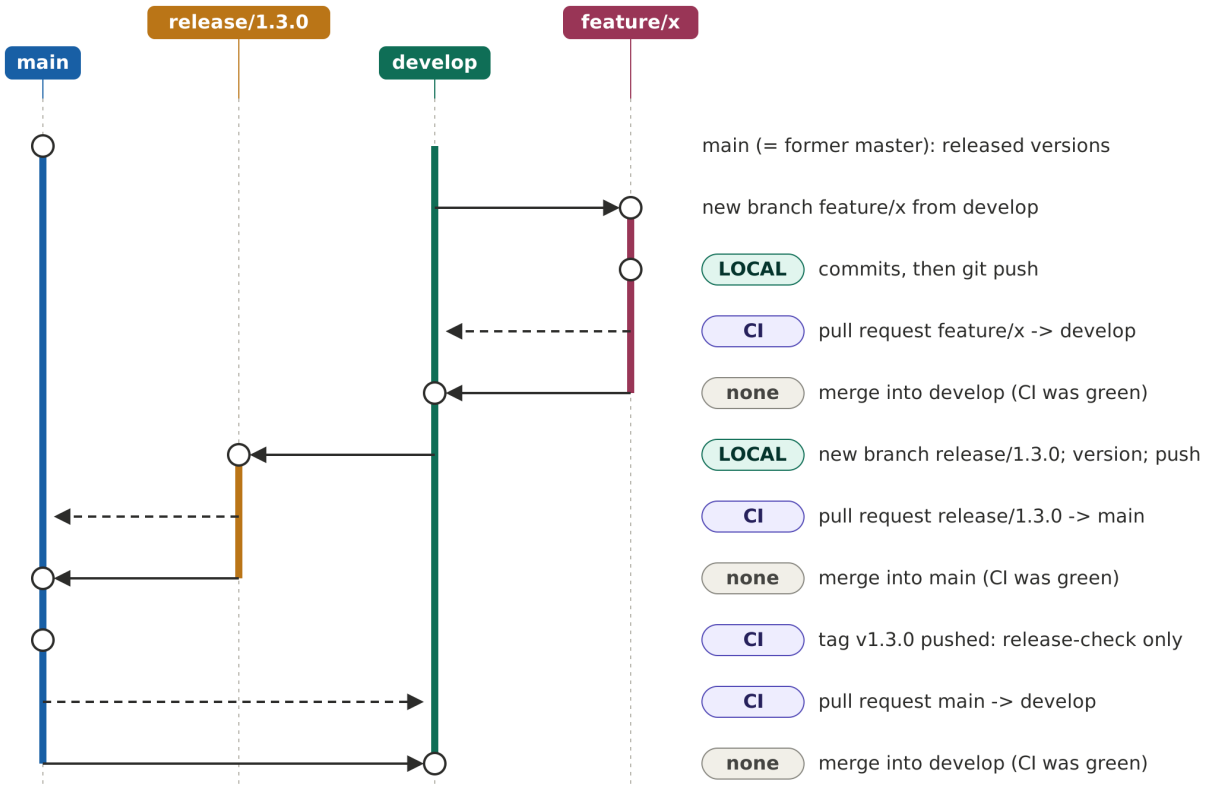


Figure 2: Feature and release, done by hand

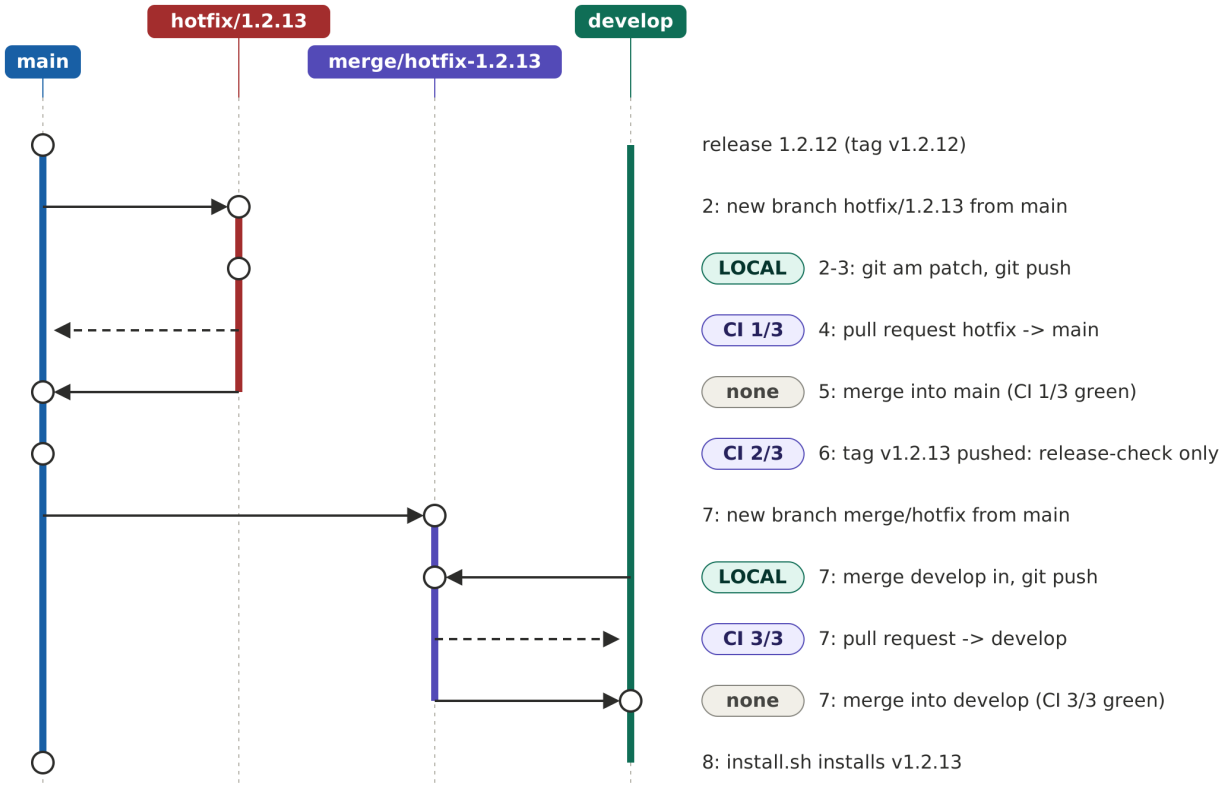


Figure 3: Hotfix with `mediatools update`; the numbers are the steps of `apply-release.sh`

Flow	LOCAL runs	CI runs on GitHub
feature	1	1 (pull request into `develop`)
release	1	3 (pull request into `main`, tag, pull request `main` -> `develop`)
hotfix (`mediatools update`)	2	3, printed as `CI 1/3` ... `CI 3/3`

4.3 What `mediatools update` prints

Since 1.2.13 the script announces every run before it waits for it and closes with a table of all CI runs (also when a step fails):

```
--- local gates (pre-push hook): tools/check.sh on this PC with Python 3.13.x;
    GitHub starts no run for this push (hotfix/1.2.13 has no push trigger)
--- 1.2.13 CI 1/3: pull_request on hotfix/1.2.13 (commit 3f2a9c1)
    checks:  merge result of hotfix/1.2.13 and main, Python 3.10/3.14
    purpose: required check: branch protection allows the merge into main only when green
    run:     https://github.com/peddanet/mediatools/actions/runs/<id>

CI runs on GitHub:
  run              trigger                                  result     url
  1.2.13 CI 1/3    pull_request hotfix/1.2.13               success    https://...
  1.2.13 CI 2/3    push v1.2.13                             success    https://...
  1.2.13 CI 3/3    pull_request merge/hotfix-1.2.13         success    https://...
```

5 The runner: which machine, how much of it, who pays

5.1 What a job gets

Each job runs on a **fresh virtual machine** that is created for the job and deleted afterwards; nothing survives from one job or run to the next (caches and artifacts must be stored explicitly). The machine carries a runner agent that executes the steps, and a short-lived token (`GITHUB_TOKEN`) valid only for this repository and this job.

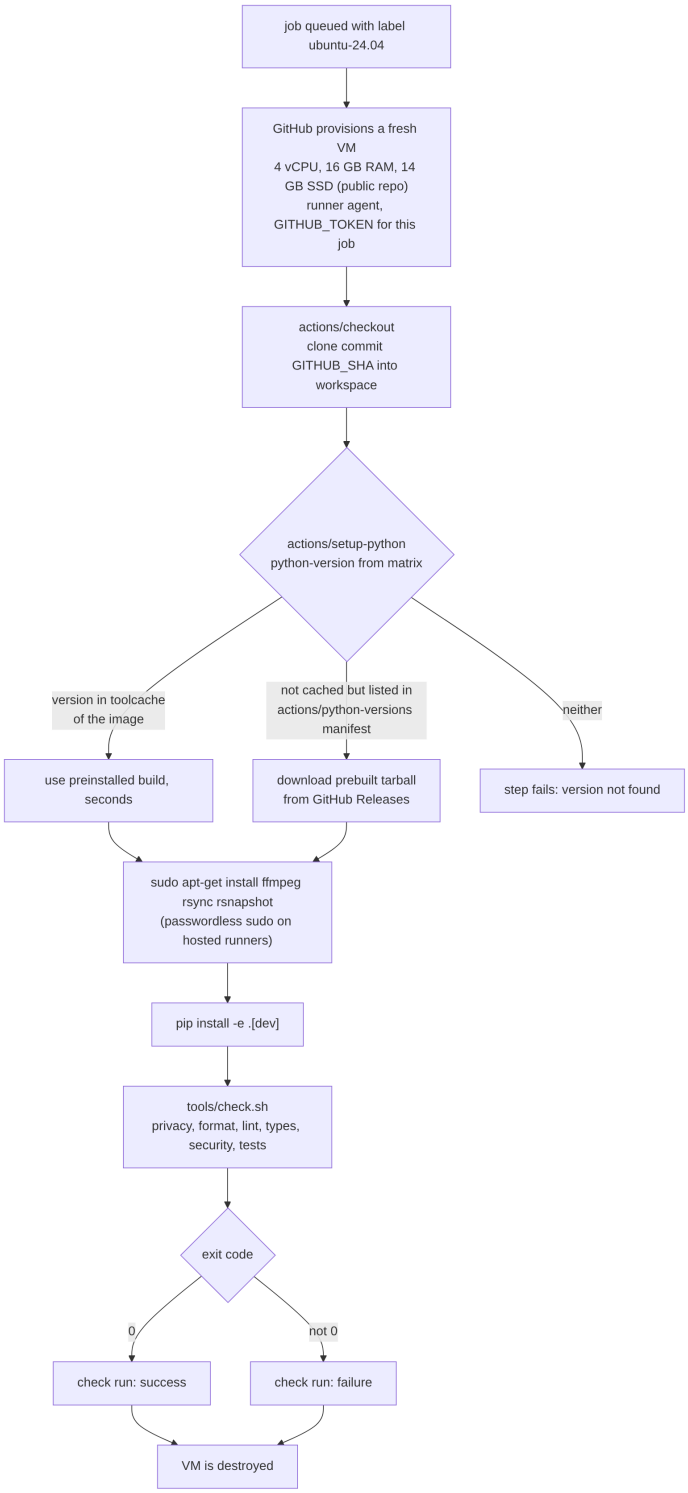


Figure 4: Inside one matrix job

Property	Standard Linux runner, public repository
Hardware	4 vCPU, 16 GB RAM, 14 GB SSD
Hardware (private repository)	2 vCPU, 8 GB RAM, 14 GB SSD

Property	Standard Linux runner, public repository
Operating system	image `ubuntu-24.04` (= `ubuntu-latest`), Azure kernel
User / privileges	user `runner`, **passwordless sudo**
Preinstalled	compilers, Docker, `gh`, several Python/Node/Go versions (“toolcache”)
Max. job duration	6 h, then the job is terminated (adjustable down with `timeout-minutes`)
Max. run duration	35 days including waiting
Concurrency (Free plan)	20 jobs at a time across all repositories, 5 of them macOS
Matrix size	max. 256 jobs per run

5.2 Can one choose the machine? Can one “request resources”?

One chooses a **label**, not resources. Each label stands for a fixed machine size and image:

Label	Machine
`ubuntu-latest`, `ubuntu-24.04`, `ubuntu-22.04`	Linux x64 VM
`ubuntu-24.04-arm`, `ubuntu-22.04-arm`	Linux arm64 VM
`ubuntu-slim`	single-CPU **container** instead of a VM, short jobs only
`windows-latest`, `windows-2025`, `windows-2022`	Windows Server VM
`macos-latest`, `macos-15`, `macos-26` …	macOS VM (Apple silicon)
custom name	**larger runner** (more vCPU/RAM, GPU), configured in the account, **always billed**
`self-hosted` + own labels	own machine with the runner agent installed

There is no key like “give me 8 GB for this step”. More resources mean a different label: a larger runner (paid, Team/Enterprise plans) or an own machine (self-hosted). `runs-on` may itself use the matrix (`runs-on: ${{ matrix.os }}`), so one workflow can test Linux, Windows and macOS in one run.

Image contents change weekly; GitHub announces removals in advance in the `actions/runner-images` repository. The exact image version of a run is printed in the “Set up job” section of its log.

5.3 Cost

Repository	Standard runners	Larger runners
public (mediatools)	free, no minute limit	billed
private, Free plan	2,000 min/month included, 500 MB artifact storage	billed
self-hosted (any)	free (own hardware and electricity)	-

For mediatools one run of the matrix costs nothing. The only practical limit is the concurrency of 20 jobs and the 6 h per job.

6 Python versions

6.1 How a version gets onto the VM

`actions/setup-python` resolves the requested version in this order:

1. **Toolcache** of the image: a few recent CPython versions (and PyPy) are preinstalled; using one takes seconds.
2. **Manifest download**: if the version is not preinstalled but is listed in `versions-manifest.json` of the repository `actions/python-versions`, a prebuilt archive is downloaded from GitHub Releases and installed.
3. Otherwise the step fails with "version not found".

The action then puts this Python first in `PATH`, so `python` and `pip` in all following steps are that version.

6.2 Which versions can be written into the matrix

Syntax in `python-version`	Effect
`"3.13"`	newest available 3.13.x
`"3.13.9"`	exactly this patch release (if in the manifest)
`"3.x"`	newest stable 3.x
`">=3.10 <3.14"`	SemVer range, newest match
`"3.15"` + `allow-prereleases: true`	alpha/beta/rc, if the final is not yet out
`"3.13t"`	free-threaded build (no GIL), 3.13 and later
`"pypy3.10"`	PyPy implementation
`"graalpy-24.1"`	GraalPy implementation
`python-version-file: .python-version`	read the version from a file in the repository

Version strings must be **quoted**: unquoted `3.10` is the YAML number 3.1. Every value in the list creates one more job; adding a version costs one more VM per run, which is free for a public repository.

Not possible: an arbitrary version that is in neither the toolcache nor the manifest (very old releases, own builds). For those there are two ways: build/install it in a step yourself (slow), or run the job in a container image that contains it (chapter 7).

6.3 The matrix of mediatools

Python 3.10 reached its end of life in October 2026 (final release 3.10.22 on 2026-10-01). GitHub removes end-of-life versions from the images with advance notice (Python 3.9 was removed on 2026-01-12) and announces a removal from the manifest about six months ahead. 3.10 will therefore work for some time, but not indefinitely.

Since 1.5.1 the matrix is 3.10 and 3.14 (from 1.2.13 to 1.5.0 it was 3.10, 3.12, 3.13, 3.14); the action is `actions/setup-python@v6`. The oldest and the newest supported version catch most version-dependent errors; the pre-push hook adds the version of the developer PC. 3.10 stays as long as `requires-python = ">=3.10"` must hold for a target system (Ubuntu 22.04 ships 3.10 as system Python). The required checks of the branch protection are `gates (3.10)` and `gates (3.14)` (chapter 9).

7 Docker containers

Containers can be used in three ways; all three require a **Linux** runner (on GitHub-hosted runners: Ubuntu).

7.1 The whole job in a container: `jobs.<id>.container`

```yaml
jobs:
  gates-container:
    runs-on: ubuntu-24.04          # the VM only serves as Docker host
    container:
      image: python:3.13-slim      # any image from Docker Hub or ghcr.io
    steps:
      - uses: actions/checkout@v4
      - run: apt-get update && apt-get install -y ffmpeg rsync rsnapshot
      - run: pip install -e ".[dev]" && tools/check.sh
```

All `run:` steps then execute **inside** the image. Consequences:

- No `setup-python`: the Python of the image is used. This is the way to test a version or distribution that the manifest does not provide, e.g. exactly the Debian or Ubuntu release of a target machine (`image: ubuntu:22.04`, `debian:13`).
- Commands run as the image's default user, usually root; `apt-get` works without `sudo` (which is mostly not even installed).
- The default shell is `sh`, not `bash`; `tools/check.sh` is unaffected because of its own shebang line, inline `run:` scripts with bash syntax need `shell: bash` (and bash in the image).
- The image is pulled on every run; large images cost time.

7.2 Additional containers beside the job: `services`

`services:` starts further containers (database, cache, mail server) for the duration of the job, for integration tests. A job in a container reaches a service by its label as host name; a job directly on the VM reaches it via `localhost` and a mapped port. mediatools needs none.

7.3 Docker inside steps

Docker is preinstalled on the Ubuntu images, so a step may simply call `docker build` or `docker run`. This is the usual way to build and push images of an own project.

7.4 Choice for mediatools

`setup-python` on the VM is the faster and simpler variant for "does the code work with Python 3.x". A container job is worth it only for the question "does it work on exactly distribution X with its packaged ffmpeg". Both can coexist in one workflow as separate jobs.

8 The `gh` tool and the GitHub API

8.1 Two different channels

Channel	Used by	Carries
git protocol (HTTPS or SSH)	`git push`, `git fetch`	commits, branches, tags
GitHub API (`https://api.github.com`)	`gh`, the web UI, actions	everything else: PRs, checks, runs, settings

`git push` does not use the API; it only transports objects. Everything GitHub-specific (pull requests, checks, branch protection, workflow runs) exists only in the API. `gh` is a client for that API.

8.2 REST and GraphQL

GitHub offers two API styles:

- **REST (v3)**: one URL per resource, HTTP verbs for actions, e.g. `GET /repos/{owner}/{repo}/pulls`, `PUT /repos/{owner}/{repo}/branches/{branch}/protection`.
- **GraphQL (v4)**: one URL `POST /graphql`; the request contains a query that names exactly the fields wanted, several objects in one call.

The `gh` subcommands (`gh pr`, `gh run`, ...) use whichever fits internally. `gh api` gives direct access to both: an endpoint path means REST, the word `graphql` means GraphQL.

```
# REST: list the last three workflow runs (normal user)
gh api 'repos/{owner}/{repo}/actions/runs?per_page=3' \
       --jq '.workflow_runs[] | [.name, .head_branch, .conclusion] | @tsv'

# GraphQL: names of the last three releases
gh api graphql -F owner='{owner}' -F name='{repo}' -f query='
  query($owner:String!, $name:String!) {
    repository(owner:$owner, name:$name) {
      releases(last:3) { nodes { tagName } } } }'
```

Option	Meaning
`{owner}`, `{repo}`, `{branch}`	placeholders, filled from the clone in the current directory
`-X, --method`	HTTP method, default `GET` (`POST` as soon as fields are given)
`-f key=value`	string field
`-F key=value`	typed field (numbers, `true`, `@file` reads a file)
`--input file`	request body from a file, `-` = standard input
`--jq expr`	filter the JSON answer with jq syntax
`--paginate`	fetch all pages of a long result
`-i, --include`	print HTTP status and headers
`--verbose`	print the full request and response

8.3 Authentication

`gh auth login` (normal user, once per machine) runs a browser flow and obtains an OAuth token. The token is stored in the **system credential store**; on Linux that is the Secret Service (GNOME Keyring, KWallet), whose files live in the user's home directory. Only if no credential store is available does `gh` fall back to a plain text entry in `~/.config/gh/hosts.yml`; the option `--insecure-storage` forces that. This matters for the rule "passwords only inside the encrypted home": the keyring variant complies; check with

```
gh auth status          # shows account, scopes and where the token is stored
```

If the environment variable `GH_TOKEN` (or `GITHUB_TOKEN`) is set, `gh` uses it instead of the stored token. Inside a workflow this is the way to use `gh`: `env: GH_TOKEN: ${{ github.token }}`.

Every API call carries the token in the `Authorization` header over HTTPS. GitHub checks the token's permissions on the repository; branch protection is enforced by the server, so no client (web, `gh`, `curl`) can bypass it.

8.4 The calls made by `apply-release.sh`

Command	What it does via the API
`gh pr list --head hotfix/X --base main --state open --json url`	look for an already open PR (makes the script re-runnable)
`gh pr create --base main --title "Hotfix X" --fill`	create the PR; this **event** starts the matrix

Command	What it does via the API
`gh run list ... --commit SHA` / `gh run view ID`	find the run of the pushed commit, its URL and its state
`gh pr checks URL --watch`	poll the check state every 10 s until all are done
`gh pr merge URL --merge --delete-branch`	merge commit into `main`, delete the remote branch; refused if protection is not satisfied
`gh run list --branch vX --event push --limit 1 --json databaseId`	find the run started by the tag push
`gh run watch ID --exit-status`	follow that run; non-zero exit status if it fails

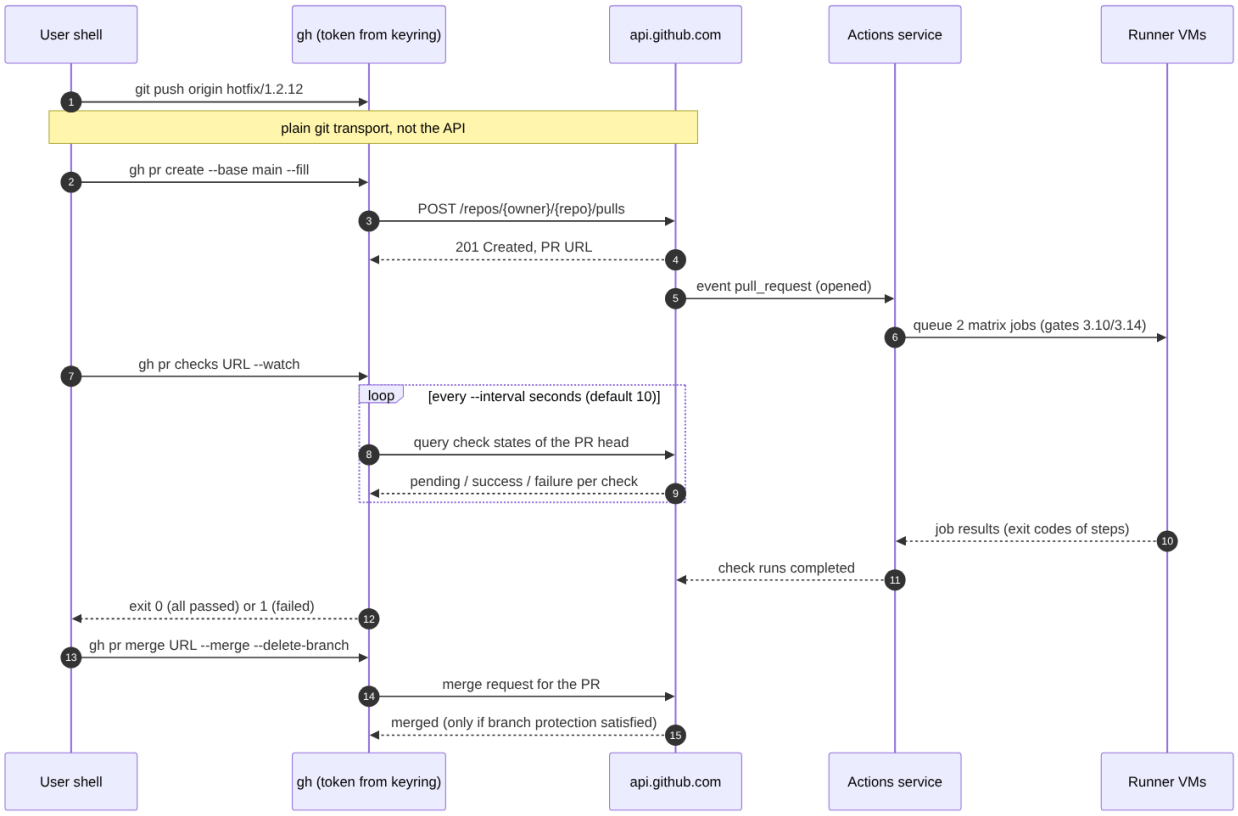


Figure 5: Pull request flow through the API

Exit codes of `gh pr checks`: 0 all checks passed, 1 at least one failed, 8 checks still pending (without `--watch`).

A short network loss must not stop an update half way. Since 1.2.14 the script therefore treats the calls in two groups. **Reading calls** (`gh run list`, `gh run view`, `gh pr list`) are repeated up to five times, 10 s apart (`gh_read`). **Watching** (`gh pr checks --watch`, `gh run watch`) ends with a non-zero code both for a red run and for a lost connection; the script then asks GitHub for the state of the run: `completed success` continues, `completed` with any other result stops the update, anything else (still queued or running) resumes watching, at most five times. Calls that change something (`gh pr create`, `gh pr merge`) are not repeated blindly; after a failure the whole update is started again, which is safe because every step can be repeated (an open PR is reused, the hotfix branch is rebuilt).

Useful options of `gh pr checks`: `--fail-fast` (stop watching at the first failure), `--required` (only required checks), `--interval N`.

9 Branch protection and status checks

Branch protection is a server-side rule per branch, set once with a REST call (normal user, repository owner):

```
gh api -X PUT "repos/peddanet/mediatools/branches/main/protection" --input - <<'EOF'
{ "required_status_checks": { "strict": true,
    "contexts": ["gates (3.10)", "gates (3.14)"] },
  "enforce_admins": true,
  "required_pull_request_reviews": { "required_approving_review_count": 0 },
  "restrictions": null, "allow_force_pushes": false, "allow_deletions": false }
EOF
```

Field	Effect
`contexts`	names of the checks that must succeed; they must match the job names exactly
`strict: true`	the PR branch must be **up to date** with the target before merging; otherwise it must be updated and tested again
`enforce_admins: true`	the owner is bound too
`required_pull_request_reviews`	changes only through a PR; 0 approvals because there is a single maintainer
`allow_force_pushes` / `allow_deletions`	history of `main`/`develop` cannot be rewritten or deleted

Consequences: a check name that is no longer produced (e.g. after removing 3.10 from the matrix) blocks every merge until the rule is updated; a new matrix entry is not required until it is added to `contexts`. Job names should be unique across all workflows, otherwise the check result is ambiguous.

10 Self-hosted runners and Forgejo

A **self-hosted runner** is the GitHub runner agent installed on an own machine; jobs select it with `runs-on: [self-hosted, linux, ...]`. It is free of charge, has the hardware one provides and keeps its state between jobs (no fresh VM; cleaning up is the owner's job). For a public repository it is a security risk: a pull request from a stranger can execute code on that machine. For mediatools it is not recommended.

Forgejo Actions (local server) uses a very similar YAML syntax. It reads workflows from `.forgejo/workflows/`; if that directory does not exist, it falls back to `.github/workflows/`. The Forgejo server does not run jobs itself: a separately installed **Forgejo Runner** fetches and executes them. There, a `runs-on` label maps to a container image (e.g. `docker://node:20-bookworm`), i.e. every job is a container job in the sense of chapter 7. Forgejo states that its Actions are designed to be familiar to GitHub users but not to be compatible; workflows have to be tested there before they are relied on.

11 Cheat sheet

All commands run as a normal user in the clone.

```
gh run list --limit 5                          # last runs of the repository
gh run view RUN_ID                             # jobs and their result
gh run view RUN_ID --log-failed                # only the logs of failed steps
gh run rerun RUN_ID --failed                   # rerun only failed jobs
gh run watch RUN_ID --exit-status              # follow a running run
gh workflow run quality-gates --ref BRANCH     # start manually (workflow_dispatch)
gh pr checks --watch --fail-fast               # checks of the PR of the current branch
gh api repos/{owner}/{repo}/branches/main/protection --jq .required_status_checks
gh auth status                                 # who am I, where is the token
```

12 Glossary

Action Reusable program referenced with `uses:` (e.g. `actions/checkout@v4`); the part after `@` is a tag or commit of the action's repository. Docs

Branch protection Server-side rule that restricts pushes and merges on a branch. Docs

Check run Result of one job, attached to a commit SHA; shown in the PR and evaluated by branch protection.

Event Occurrence that starts workflows (`push`, `pull_request`, `workflow_dispatch`, ...). Docs

GITHUB_TOKEN Token created per job, valid for the repository only, expires at the end of the job. Docs

GraphQL Query language of GitHub API v4; one endpoint, client names the fields. Docs

Job Unit of work on one runner; jobs of a run execute in parallel unless linked by `needs`.

Label Name in `runs-on` that selects a runner type. Docs

Larger runner GitHub-hosted runner with more resources than standard; always billed.

main Branch with the released versions; the same as `master` in older git-flow texts (GitHub default name since 2020-10-01). Changelog

Matrix Expansion of one job definition into several jobs, one per value combination. Docs

Pull request Request to merge one branch into another; GitHub tests the merge result before the merge is allowed. Docs

REST Resource-oriented GitHub API v3. Docs

Run One execution of a workflow, triggered by one event.

Runner Machine with the runner agent that executes a job; GitHub-hosted or self-hosted.

Service container Additional container started beside a job (`services:`). Docs

Toolcache Directory of preinstalled tool versions on the runner image, used by the `setup-*` actions.

Workflow YAML file in `.github/workflows/` that defines events and jobs. Docs

13 Sources

- actions/checkout, release v5.0.0 (runtime Node.js 24; removes the "Node.js 20 is deprecated" annotation of v4): https://github.com/actions/checkout/releases/tag/v5.0.0
- actions/setup-python, README, *Caching packages dependencies* (`cache: pip`, `cache-dependency-path`, `pyproject.toml` as dependency file): https://github.com/actions/setup-python#caching-packages-dependencies
- GitHub Docs, *GitHub-hosted runners reference* (labels, hardware, fresh VM per job, sudo): https://docs.github.com/en/actions/reference/runners/github-hosted-runners
- GitHub changelog 2020-08-26, *Set the default branch for newly-created repositories* (`master` -> `main` from 2020-10-01): https://github.blog/changelog/2020-08-26-set-the-default-branch-for-newly-created-repositories/
- GitHub Docs, *Actions limits* (6 h per job, 35 days per run, 256 matrix jobs, concurrency per plan): https://docs.github.com/en/actions/reference/limits
- GitHub Docs, *Usage limits, billing and administration* (free for public repositories and self-hosted runners): https://docs.github.com/en/actions/reference/usage-limits-billing-and-

administration
- GitHub Docs, *About billing for GitHub Actions* (included minutes, larger runners billed): https://docs.github.com/en/billing/managing-billing-for-github-actions/about-billing-for-github-actions
- GitHub Docs, *Running variations of jobs* (matrix, fail-fast, max-parallel, include/exclude): https://docs.github.com/en/actions/how-tos/write-workflows/choose-what-workflows-do/run-job-variations
- GitHub Docs, *Running jobs in a container*: https://docs.github.com/en/actions/how-tos/write-workflows/choose-where-workflows-run/run-jobs-in-a-container
- GitHub Docs, *Creating PostgreSQL service containers* (Linux only, networking of service containers): https://docs.github.com/en/actions/tutorials/use-containerized-services/create-postgresql-service-containers
- GitHub Docs, *Use GITHUB_TOKEN for authentication in workflows*: https://docs.github.com/en/actions/tutorials/authenticate-with-github_token
- GitHub Docs, *About protected branches* (strict/loose checks, unique job names): https://docs.github.com/en/repositories/configuring-branches-and-merges-in-your-repository/managing-protected-branches/about-protected-branches
- actions/setup-python, README and advanced usage (version syntax, free-threaded, PyPy, GraalPy, version file): https://github.com/actions/setup-python
- actions/python-versions (manifest of downloadable builds, removal notice six months ahead): https://github.com/actions/python-versions
- actions/runner-images (image contents, announcements; issue #13468 removal of Python 3.9 on 2026-01-12): https://github.com/actions/runner-images, https://github.com/actions/runner-images/issues/13468
- Python Developer's Guide, *Status of Python versions* (3.10 end of life October 2026): https://devguide.python.org/versions/
- GitHub CLI manual, `gh api`, `gh auth login`, `gh pr checks`: https://cli.github.com/manual/gh_api, https://cli.github.com/manual/gh_auth_login, https://cli.github.com/manual/gh_pr_checks; local help texts of `gh` 2.89.0 (flags and exit codes verified 2026-11-10)
- cli/cli pull request #7023 (token moved from `hosts.yml` to the system keyring): https://github.com/cli/cli/pull/7023
- Forgejo documentation, *Forgejo Actions user guide* (runner required, fallback to `.github/workflows`, not designed to be compatible): https://forgejo.org/docs/latest/user/actions/overview/